

Chapter 105-1 - My Love

"I'm not lying to you." Ning Fuyi held her around the waist, resting her face on her head, smelling the faint herbal fragrance in her hair.

Horse hooves galloped, wheels rolled over grassland and shallows. From time to time, the sound of Jiuying cracking her whip to train the horses came from outside the carriage. Grass threads flew past the windows, and the sky stretched endlessly.

Inside the carriage, the two leaned against each other, warm and peaceful.

Gunan County¹ was indeed much livelier than the town. White walls and blue tiles, houses arranged in neat rows, with two canals crisscrossing through the middle. Merchant ships from various places came and went.

In the distance, green mountains looked like veiled beauties, with mist rising up to the clouds.

Ning Fuyi helped Su Mo down from the carriage. Su Mo, wearing her veil, looked around carefully with curiosity in her eyes. Several ordinary girls with graceful smiles walked past them hand in hand, stirring up waves of fragrance.

Su Mo instinctively stepped back, but her palm was tightly grasped by another warm hand. The solid touch made her steady her steps.

"Hey, we'll go find an inn to stable the carriage. You take Su Mo around by yourself." Jiuying dismounted and teasingly pinched Ning Fuyi's shoulder.

Without waiting for her to say more, she turned and walked toward the stable, with Hannya and Xique following behind. Hannya turned back to make a face at her.

This crow had only been in the mortal world for a few months and was already being disrespectful. Ning Fuyi frowned at her.

When she looked at Su Mo, her brow smoothed again, and she smiled while shaking her hand: "Where would Su Mo like to wander?"

"I'll listen, to Yiyi." Su Mo said gently.

"I heard there's a ten-li temple fair² today. If you don't mind the noise, we could go take a look." Ning Fuyi still sought her opinion.

Su Mo shook her head, covering her veil and smiling: "Don't, mind."

Following those girls from earlier was the way to the temple fair. Even from two streets away, they could hear gongs and drums, laughter and joy.

The streets were crowded with people. From time to time, girls holding fans and glistening with fragrant sweat would chatter as they passed by, all heading in one direction. Ning Fuyi pulled Su Mo to follow.

Getting closer, they discovered it was a row of stalls selling rouge, powder, precious jade, and vermillion hairpins. Young girls crowded in front of the stalls with charming smiles, picking up hairpins and powder to compare with each other.

Ning Fuyi picked up a white jade hairpin and held it up to Su Mo, feeling that the hairpin was precious yet elegant, very suitable for Su Mo. She took out silver to buy it and raised her hand to help Su Mo insert it in her hair.

Her hair was dark and lustrous, the jade hairpin like a flower petal that had fallen upon it, gentle and beautiful.

"How is it?" Ning Fuyi picked up a bronze mirror from the stall to show Su Mo.

Su Mo nodded: "I like it."

Seeing her happiness, layers of joy rippled in Ning Fuyi's heart. She pulled her further into the crowd and looked up to see a shop selling various colored flower ornaments, its owner shouting at the top of his lungs.

"Miss! Two young ladies! Come look at my Zhu Hong Lou³ flower ornaments! All grown by my own family. Though they can't compare to those pearls, jade, gold and silver, they have their own fragrance and are perfect for flourishing young women like you!"

The shopkeeper was a middle-aged woman dressed in red and green, very eye-catching, waving her handkerchief at them while speaking in Wu dialect⁴.

Su Mo was attracted by those fresh flowers. She tugged Ning Fuyi's sleeve and turned to walk to the stall, lowering her head to examine them.

Seeing her interest, Ning Fuyi suddenly had an idea. She reached out to pick up a large red carnation. The shopkeeper somehow made the flowers both soft and flourishing, with petals that wouldn't fall off.

"How long can this flower last?" Ning Fuyi asked.

"Aiya, they're all fresh, just picked this morning! Stick them on and they're lighter than jewelry, lasting all day without wilting!" The woman took the carnation from Ning Fuyi's hand, holding her handkerchief.

"Is the young lady buying for herself or her sister?" the shopkeeper smiled.

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi tightened her grip on Su Mo's hand, turned her wrist, and interlocked their fingers: "Her."

The woman's smile froze for a moment, but she quickly recovered, laughing awkwardly to cover her embarrassment: "This young lady has such beautiful eyes, so lively. I'm sure it will be most suitable..."

Su Mo's face under the veil immediately turned red to her ears. She secretly kicked Ning Fuyi, though it was a rebuke, she was actually overjoyed inside.

Ning Fuyi reached out to remove the veil from behind Su Mo's ear, but Su Mo grabbed her fingertips, looking up worriedly.

Ning Fuyi shook her head reassuringly, then flicked her fingers to remove the veil.

Su Mo had expected the shopkeeper to be scared out of her wits by the birthmark, but the other party acted as if she hadn't seen anything, focusing intently on sticking flower petals over the birthmark.

Su Mo looked at Ning Fuyi with lingering fear, and only felt much more at ease after receiving confirmation from her.

This was the first time Ning Fuyi had used immortal power in front of Su Mo, and also the only time.

The woman's hands were indeed skillful. In a short while, she had made two beautiful carnations, one large and one small, bloom on Su Mo's cheek, covering the birthmark completely.

Su Mo touched her cheek in delight, turning to face the endless stream of passersby. Most people didn't give her a second glance, and even if they did, it was only amazement at her beauty, with nothing else in their eyes.

For the first time, she faced the world without a veil. This feeling was much more wonderful than she had imagined. Her face wasn't covered with stuffy sweat, but filled with summer breeze, and various scents poured into her nostrils without obstruction.

"Yiyi, candied hawthorn!" Su Mo gestured with her hands, then lifted her skirt and ran toward the crowd, her figure light and joyful.

Ning Fuyi had never seen her so happy. Smiles spread across her face as she turned back to give the woman double payment, then quickly followed Su Mo.

The temple fair had many fresh things. With her veil gone, Su Mo opened her heart and pulled Ning Fuyi from beginning to end. Ning Fuyi patiently accompanied her throughout.

By the end, when the setting sun slanted westward and vendors were pulling their carts away, Su Mo was too tired to lift her legs. She turned and sat on a clean bluestone at the end of the long street.

Ning Fuyi also sat beside her. Su Mo grasped her hand, leaning sideways against her shoulder with a smile, gazing at the colorful sky.

It had been a very long time since she had seen any filthy things, and a very long time since she had felt fear. It seemed like the twenty-two years of hardship before were all for this year and a half of meeting Yiyi.

She was very satisfied.

It was just a bit short.

"Yiyi, when I was young, my mother said that two people who see the first red leaf of late summer at the same time have destined fate." Su Mo suddenly raised her hand.

Ning Fuyi followed her gaze upward and indeed saw a red leaf quietly hanging on the tip of a lush plane tree above them.

The fiery red color mixed among the green, out of place yet outstanding.

Ning Fuyi held back her words that were about to spill out, secretly crooked her finger, so the tree tip moved without wind and the red leaf fluttered down.

Ning Fuyi grabbed Su Mo's arm and raised it toward the sky. Su Mo caught the red leaf and held it up delightedly before Ning Fuyi's eyes.

"Yiyi, look!" She laughed and jumped up, her blue dress spinning in a circle, the flower petals on her face brilliantly dazzling.

Ning Fuyi watched her figure, her eyes gradually moistening with a hint of red.

"I see." She smiled.

Footnotes:

1. **Gunan County (沽南县)** - A fictional county name, with "Gu" meaning "to sell" and "nan" meaning "south," suggesting a commercial area south of their location.
2. **Ten-li temple fair (十里庙市)** - A traditional Chinese market fair that extends for ten li (about 5 kilometers), typically held around temples during festivals, featuring various vendors, food, and entertainment.
3. **Zhu Hong Lou (朱红楼)** - Literally "Vermillion Red Building," likely the name of the flower shop or the area where it's located.
4. **Wu dialect (吴语)** - A group of Chinese dialects spoken in the Yangtze River Delta region, including areas around Shanghai, known for its distinctive soft tones.